

CA.5 Forms & Documents Index

Every document a California owner-builder meets — what each one is, when it is needed, and which office it comes from.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. California writes one building code for the whole state — Title 24 — but permits are issued by 58 counties and hundreds of incorporated cities, and state law lets each of them amend that code for local conditions. Confirm every item with the city or county building department that will issue your permit before you rely on it. Form names and numbers are local; the obligations behind them are not.

Documents a California owner-builder will encounter

Document	What it is and when you need it	Where it comes from
Building permit application	The main application — and in California a statutory form : § 19825 requires every city and county to use one "in substantially the same form." Carries the declarations below. When : after zoning, school fees, septic and fire review are lined up.	City building department if inside city limits; county if unincorporated
Owner-Builder Declaration	Part of that application, signed under penalty of perjury . You check the basis for your exemption and acknowledge the limits on selling. Bring identification — the agency must verify you are the owner on title. When : at application. See CA.1 before you sign it.	On the permit application (H&S § 19825; B&P § 7031.5)
Notice to Property Owner	A second signed document, on your building department's own letterhead: the "Owner's Acknowledgment and Verification of Information," twelve statements you read and initial one at a time , covering liability for unlicensed workers, when you become an employer, building to sell, and latent defects after you sell. When : ask for it before application day. No permit issues without it, and an agent may not sign it without prior approval.	Your building department (H&S § 19825(c))
Workers' Compensation Declaration	Also under penalty of perjury, on the same application: you self-insure, you carry a policy, or you certify you will not employ anyone so as to become subject to the comp laws. Revisit it the day you first pay a helper.	On the permit application (Lab. § 3800(a))
Authorization of Agent	If anyone other than you signs the Owner-Builder Declaration, the owner must complete this and return it to the agency before the permit issues . California does allow an agent — but on a form, in advance.	Owner completes; returned to the issuing agency (H&S § 19825(b))

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Construction lending agency block	The application must give space to name your construction lender, or to note that there is none.	On the permit application (Civil Code § 8172)
School district fee certificate	Certification that the school facilities fee has been paid, or does not apply. Your building permit cannot issue without it — or, where the district elected otherwise, your final inspection and certificate of occupancy cannot. When: start early; the rate is per square foot and the district sets it.	The school district whose boundary contains the parcel (Ed. Code § 17620)
Title 24 energy compliance documents	CF1R Certificate of Compliance with the application, CF2R Certificate of Installation from whoever installed each measure, and CF3R Certificate of Verification from the rater. On a wood-framed dwelling of two stories or fewer you may sign the CF1R yourself; the CF3R you may not.	Your energy consultant; CF3R verification by an independent ECC-Rater (not a HERS rater — the program changed in 2026)
Fire sprinkler plans	Design for the automatic sprinkler system every new California dwelling requires , to NFPA 13D or CRC § R309.3. Affects your water service, pressure, and on a well your tank and pump. When: at design, not after plan check.	A C-16 fire protection contractor; reviewed by the building department or the fire authority
Septic permit	Issued under the State Water Board's OWTS Policy, in most counties through an approved Local Agency Management Program. Preceded by a site and soil evaluation, which is what actually decides whether your land can carry a system and what it costs. When: first — before you design, ideally before you buy.	County environmental health under its LAMP; the Regional Water Board where none applies
Well permit and well completion report	Permit before drilling; the completion report is filed by the driller afterwards. The driller must hold a C-57 Water Well Contractor's License — there is no owner exception for drilling, unlike the electrical and plumbing work you may self-perform.	County environmental health; driller must be C-57 licensed (Water Code § 13750.5)
Grading permit and geotechnical report	Triggered by the volume or the slope of your earthwork, on thresholds your jurisdiction sets. A soils or geotechnical report is commonly required on sloped or filled sites and drives your foundation design.	Building department or public works; report from a licensed engineer
Construction General Permit enrollment	If your land disturbance brings you under the statewide stormwater permit, you enroll through the State Water Board's SMARTS system and receive a WDID number — before ground disturbance. Confirm coverage with your Regional Water Board.	State Water Resources Control Board, through its SMARTS system
Encroachment / driveway permit	Required to connect your driveway to a public road. Which agency issues it depends on who maintains the road — city, county, or Caltrans for a state highway.	City or county public works; Caltrans if a state highway

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WUI pre-construction certification	In a fire hazard zone, before construction the owner must obtain a certification from the building official that the dwelling as proposed complies with applicable building standards, and provide it on request to the course-of-construction insurer. Ask for it by name.	Your building official (PRC § 4291(a)(5); Gov. § 51182(a)(5))
Special inspection reports	Where your approved plans carry a special inspection schedule — common on engineered work in California's seismic design categories — an approved special inspector reports directly to the building official. You pay for it.	An approved agency; see California Building Code Chapter 17
Operation and maintenance manual	A CALGreen requirement that catches people at the very end: at the time of final inspection a manual "shall be placed in the building." When: collect appliance and equipment documentation from your first delivery, not the week of your final.	You assemble it (CRC § R109.1.6.2; CALGreen Ch. 4, Div. 4.4)
Certificate of occupancy	Issued after the final inspection when the building official finds no violations. The building may not be used or occupied until it issues. It records the code edition your permit was issued under and whether a sprinkler system was required — keep it.	Building department, at the end (CRC § R110)
Final inspection report for your insurer	In a fire hazard zone, on completion the owner must obtain from the building official a copy of the final inspection report demonstrating compliance, and provide it on request to the property insurer. File it with your insurance papers. A temporary certificate of occupancy may also be issued before the whole work is complete, for a period the building official sets (CRC § R110.3).	Your building official (PRC § 4291(a)(5); Gov. § 51182(a)(5))

Sources (verified August 2026; statutes at [leginfo.legislature.ca.gov](https://leginfo.ca.gov)). The permit application, Owner-Builder Declaration, Workers' Compensation Declaration and agent authorization are set out in the text of Health & Safety Code § 19825(a) and (b); the underlying duty to state the basis of exemption, with a civil penalty of not more than \$500, is B&P § 7031.5; the comp declaration is required by Labor Code § 3800(a); the construction lender block by Civil Code § 8172. School district certification gates the permit under Education Code § 17620(b), or the final inspection and certificate of occupancy under § 17620(c). Automatic sprinklers in every one- and two-family dwelling: 2025 California Residential Code § R309.2 — renumbered from § R313.2 in the previous edition. Inspections, the operation and maintenance manual, and the certificate of occupancy: § R109, § R109.1.6.2 and § R110. Special inspections: California Building Code Chapter 17. Wildfire certification and final report: Public Resources Code § 4291(a)(5) and Government Code § 51182(a)(5), both as amended by AB 1455 (Stats. 2025, Ch. 731). Well drilling license: Water Code § 13750.5. Septic and stormwater: State Water Resources Control Board OWTS Policy and Construction General Permit. **This kit prints no fee figures** — school fees, permit fees, septic and grading fees are all set locally or adjusted periodically, and a stale number is worse than none.